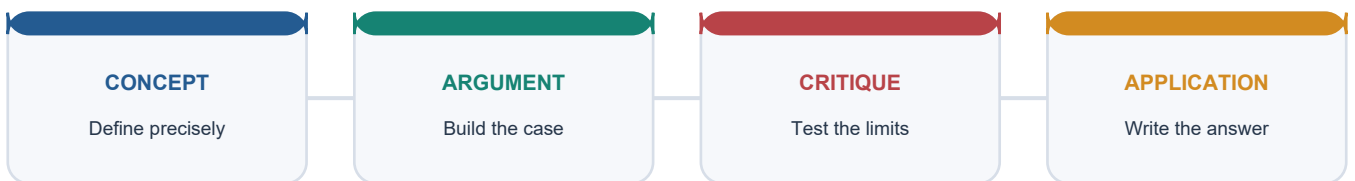


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Jainism and Buddhism: Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Jainism and Buddhism: Solved Practice Workbook

Exact practice contract: 32 original hard MCQs precede all PYQs; A/B/C/D each occurs eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 traps are unique. Verified, inferred and provisional PYQ keys remain visibly distinct.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

Exact practice contract: These 32 questions appear before every PYQ. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times. All 128 option explanations and all 32 examiner traps are question-specific.

Q1

1

Which formulation best explains the sixth-century BCE setting?

- A. Urban, political and social change widened audiences, but did not mechanically determine doctrine.
- B. Only merchant resentment created heterodoxy, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- C. The movements arose outside towns and states, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- D. Iron technology alone produced both religions, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Second urbanisation, states and new elites supplied context; ideas and institutions still require independent explanation. It matches the tested setting distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q1-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise setting benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'urban, political and social change widened audiences, but did not mechanically determine doctrine.'. [Q1-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise setting benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'urban, political and social change widened audiences, but did not mechanically determine doctrine.'. [Q1-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about setting into a universal claim. [Q1-D]

Examiner trap 1: For setting, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 1 specifically tests the boundary around Urban, political and social change widened audiences, but did not mechanically determine doctrine.

Q2

2

Which is the safest historical statement about the Tirthankaras?

- A. Rishabhanatha is proven by Harappan seals, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- B. Parshvanatha is a plausible pre-Mahavira teacher, while the full sequence is primarily sacred tradition.
- C. All twenty-four are securely dated by inscriptions, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- D. Mahavira was the first Tirthankara, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise jain chronology benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'parshvanatha is a plausible pre-mahavira teacher, while the full sequence is primarily sacred tradition.'. [Q2-A]
- **B:** Correct: Evidence confidence is graded: Mahavira is historical, Parshva plausible, and remote traditional chronology cannot be archaeologically asserted. It matches the tested Jain chronology distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q2-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise jain chronology benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'parshvanatha is a plausible pre-mahavira teacher, while the full sequence is primarily sacred tradition.'. [Q2-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It telescopes chronology or attributes a gradual development in jain chronology to one beginning. [Q2-D]

Examiner trap 2: For Jain chronology, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 2 specifically tests the boundary around Parshvanatha is a plausible pre-Mahavira teacher, while the full sequence is primarily sacred tradition.

Q3

3

Nigantha Nataputta/Nayaputta in Pali sources refers to:

- A. Maitreya.
- B. Gautama Buddha.
- C. Mahavira.
- D. Nagarjuna.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise identities benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'mahavira.'. [Q3-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise identities benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'mahavira.'. [Q3-B]
- **C:** Correct: The 2024 epithets PYQ tests this person-name firewall: Buddha is Shakyamuni/Tathagata; Mahavira is Nataputta. It matches the tested identities distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q3-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise identities benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'mahavira.'. [Q3-D]

Examiner trap 3: For identities, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 3 specifically tests the boundary around Mahavira.

Q4

4

In Jain ontology, dharma-dravya is:

- A. Karmic merit stored in a soul.
- B. The creator principle, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.
- C. The moral duty of a householder only.
- D. The medium that enables motion.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise jain ontology benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'the medium that enables motion.'. [Q4-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the jain ontology distinction. [Q4-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about jain ontology into a universal claim. [Q4-C]

- **D:** Correct: Dharma and adharma as substances are media of motion and rest, not simply ethical good and evil. It matches the tested Jain ontology distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q4-D]

Examiner trap 4: For Jain ontology, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 4 specifically tests the boundary around The medium that enables motion.

Q5

5

Which sequence correctly describes Jain liberation mechanics?

- A. Asrava -> bandha -> samvara -> nirjara -> moksha.
- B. Bandha -> asrava -> moksha -> nirjara -> samvara.
- C. Craving -> aggregates -> grace -> heaven.
- D. Jiva -> anatta -> nirvana -> rebirth, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Influx produces bondage; stopping new influx and shedding old karma lead to release. It matches the tested Jain karma distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q5-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain karma benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'asrava -> bandha -> samvara -> nirjara -> moksha.'. [Q5-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain karma benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'asrava -> bandha -> samvara -> nirjara -> moksha.'. [Q5-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the Jain karma distinction. [Q5-D]

Examiner trap 5: For Jain karma, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 5 specifically tests the boundary around Asrava -> bandha -> samvara -> nirjara -> moksha.

Q6

6

Which item is not one of the five Jain vows?

- A. Ahimsa, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- B. Right concentration.
- C. Asteya, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- D. Aparigraha.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain vows benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'right concentration.'. [Q6-A]
- **B:** Correct: Right concentration is an Eightfold Path factor; Jain vows are ahimsa, satya, asteya, brahmacharya and aparigraha. It matches the tested Jain vows distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q6-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain vows benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'right concentration.'. [Q6-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain vows benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'right concentration.'. [Q6-D]

Examiner trap 6: For Jain vows, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 6 specifically tests the boundary around Right concentration.

Q7

7

The correct distinction is:

- A. Syadvada asserts contradictions in the same respect, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- B. All three mean total scepticism, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- C. Anekantavada concerns many-sided reality; nayavada standpoints; syadvada qualified predication.
- D. Nayavada is the Jain theory of karmic matter, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain epistemology benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'anekantavada concerns many-sided reality; nayavada standpoints; syadvada qualified predication.'. [Q7-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain epistemology benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'anekantavada concerns many-sided reality; nayavada standpoints; syadvada qualified predication.'. [Q7-B]
- **C:** Correct: The three doctrines form a linked epistemic method but have distinct functions. It matches the tested Jain epistemology distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q7-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the Jain epistemology distinction. [Q7-D]

Examiner trap 7: For Jain epistemology, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 7 specifically tests the boundary around Anekantavada concerns many-sided reality; nayavada standpoints; syadvada qualified predication.

Q8

8

Which issue significantly differentiates major Jain sects?

- A. Whether ahimsa is valuable, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- B. Acceptance versus rejection of all Tirthankaras.
- C. Belief in karma versus no karma, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- D. Canonical survival and women's immediate liberation.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain sects benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'canonical survival and women's immediate liberation.'. [Q8-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about Jain sects into a universal claim. [Q8-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain sects benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'canonical survival and women's immediate liberation.'. [Q8-C]
- **D:** Correct: Digambara and Shvetambara differences go well beyond clothing. It matches the tested Jain sects distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q8-D]

Examiner trap 8: For Jain sects, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 8 specifically tests the boundary around Canonical survival and women's immediate liberation.

Q9

9

Sthanakvasi is best identified as:

- A. A later non-image-worship Shvetambara Jain tradition.
- B. An early Mahasanghika school, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- C. A Buddhist cave order in Andhra, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- D. A Digambara canon council, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: It is Jain and Shvetambara; its history is much later than Mahavira. It matches the tested Sthanakvasi distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q9-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise sthanakvasi benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'a later non-image-worship shvetambara jain tradition.'. [Q9-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise sthanakvasi benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'a later non-image-worship shvetambara jain tradition.'. [Q9-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise sthanakvasi benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'a later non-image-worship shvetambara jain tradition.'. [Q9-D]

Examiner trap 9: For Sthanakvasi, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 9 specifically tests the boundary around A later non-image-worship Shvetambara Jain tradition.

Q10

10

Valabhi is important in Jain history because of:

- A. Ashoka's Kalinga war, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- B. The conventional final redaction of the Shvetambara canon.
- C. Kanishka's Sarvastivada council, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- D. The Buddha's first sermon, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise jain canon benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'the conventional final redaction of the shvetambara canon.'. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct: Valabhi belongs to later Shvetambara canonical memory, not the lifetime of Mahavira. It matches the tested Jain canon distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise jain canon benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'the conventional final redaction of the shvetambara canon.'. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It telescopes chronology or attributes a gradual development in jain canon to one beginning. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: For Jain canon, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 10 specifically tests the boundary around The conventional final redaction of the Shvetambara canon.

Q11

11

Kankali Tila is especially useful for studying:

- A. The Pali council at Aluvihara, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- B. Achaemenid rule in Gandhara, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- C. Early Jain images, ayagapatas and donor communities at Mathura.
- D. Buddha's enlightenment, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain sites benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'early Jain images, ayagapatas and donor communities at Mathura.'. [Q11-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain sites benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'early Jain images, ayagapatas and donor communities at Mathura.'. [Q11-B]
- **C:** Correct: The site supplies material and inscriptional evidence for organized Jain life. It matches the tested Jain sites distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain sites benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'early Jain images, ayagapatas and donor communities at Mathura.'. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: For Jain sites, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 11 specifically tests the boundary around Early Jain images, ayagapatas and donor communities at Mathura.

Q12

12

The safest use of the Chandragupta-Bhadrabahu tradition is:

- A. As proof that Digambara and Shvetambara formed in one meeting.
- B. As a contemporary Mauryan inscription, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.
- C. As evidence that Jainism began in Karnataka, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- D. As a later southern Jain memory requiring epigraphic caution.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain spread benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'as a later southern Jain memory requiring epigraphic caution.'. [Q12-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain spread benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'as a later southern Jain memory requiring epigraphic caution.'. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It telescopes chronology or attributes a gradual development in Jain spread to one beginning. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct: Shravanabelagola's later epigraphic tradition cannot independently verify every early detail. It matches the tested Jain spread distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: For Jain spread, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 12 specifically tests the boundary around As a later southern Jain memory requiring epigraphic caution.

Q13

13

Which source most directly anchors Kharavela-era Jain patronage?

- A. The Hathigumpha inscription and Udayagiri-Khandagiri caves.
- B. The Milindapanha alone, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- C. The Rummindei pillar, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- D. The Allahabad pillar, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Hathigumpha is self-representational but provides a named Kalinga anchor. It matches the tested Jain patronage distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about Jain patronage into a universal claim. [Q13-B]

- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain patronage benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'the Hathigumpha inscription and Udayagiri-Khandagiri caves.'. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain patronage benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'the Hathigumpha inscription and Udayagiri-Khandagiri caves.'. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: For Jain patronage, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 13 specifically tests the boundary around The Hathigumpha inscription and Udayagiri-Khandagiri caves.

Q14

14

The four principal Jain gatis include all except:

- A. Manushya.
- B. Yaksha.
- C. Tiryancha.
- D. Deva.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain gatis benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'yaksha.'. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct: The four are gods, humans, hell beings and animals/plants; yaksha is not the fourth category. It matches the tested Jain gatis distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q14-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain gatis benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'yaksha.'. [Q14-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise Jain gatis benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'yaksha.'. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: For Jain gatis, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 14 specifically tests the boundary around Yaksha.

Q15

15

The first Noble Truth concerns:

- A. Ritual sacrifice, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- B. A creator god, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- C. Dukkha, the unsatisfactoriness of conditioned existence under clinging.
- D. The permanent soul, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise four truths benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'dukkha, the unsatisfactoriness of conditioned existence under clinging.'. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the four truths distinction. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct: Dukkha is broader than pain and is linked causally to craving and ignorance. It matches the tested Four Truths distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q15-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise four truths benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'dukkha, the unsatisfactoriness of conditioned existence under clinging.'. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: For Four Truths, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 15 specifically tests the boundary around Dukkha, the unsatisfactoriness of conditioned existence under clinging.

Q16

16

Dependent origination implies that:

- A. A permanent soul transmits unchanged, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- B. Events are fixed by fate, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.
- C. Craving is the first cosmic cause, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- D. Conditioned processes arise and cease with conditions.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise dependent origination benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'conditioned processes arise and cease with conditions.'. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise dependent origination benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'conditioned processes arise and cease with conditions.'. [Q16-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It telescopes chronology or attributes a gradual development in dependent origination to one beginning. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct: Conditionality allows cessation and denies both fatalism and an independent self. It matches the tested dependent origination distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: For dependent origination, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 16 specifically tests the boundary around Conditioned processes arise and cease with conditions.

Q17

17

Buddhist anatta means:

- A. No permanent independent self can be identified in the aggregates.
- B. Every person has an eternal jiva, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- C. Nothing exists conventionally, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- D. No ethical consequences exist, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Causal continuity and karma remain without a permanent atman. It matches the tested anatta distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q17-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about anatta into a universal claim. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise anatta benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'no permanent independent self can be identified in the aggregates.'. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise anatta benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'no permanent independent self can be identified in the aggregates.'. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: For anatta, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 17 specifically tests the boundary around No permanent independent self can be identified in the aggregates.

Q18

18

Buddhist karma is best understood as:

- A. Inherited caste status alone, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- B. Intentional action with ethical causal consequences.

- C. Subtle material particles binding a soul, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- D. A divine reward ledger, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about buddhist karma into a universal claim. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Correct: This distinction is essential in Jain-Buddhist comparison. It matches the tested Buddhist karma distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise buddhist karma benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'intentional action with ethical causal consequences.'. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise buddhist karma benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'intentional action with ethical causal consequences.'. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: For Buddhist karma, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 18 specifically tests the boundary around Intentional action with ethical causal consequences.

Q19

19

Nirvana is safest described as:

- A. Annihilation of a permanent atman, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- B. Political equality, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- C. Cessation of greed, hatred and delusion and release from conditioned rebirth.
- D. A creator-god's heaven, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the nirvana distinction. [Q19-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise nirvana benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'cessation of greed, hatred and delusion and release from conditioned rebirth.'. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct: The teaching cannot be reduced to death or nonexistence. It matches the tested nirvana distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q19-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the nirvana distinction. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: For nirvana, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 19 specifically tests the boundary around Cessation of greed, hatred and delusion and release from conditioned rebirth.

Q20

20

The Vinaya Pitaka primarily concerns:

- A. Royal genealogies, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- B. Only philosophical emptiness, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.
- C. Jain lay vows, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- D. Monastic discipline, procedures and rules.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise vinaya benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'monastic discipline, procedures and rules.'. [Q20-A]

- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise vinaya benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'monastic discipline, procedures and rules.'. [Q20-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the vinaya distinction. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct: Vinaya is institution history as well as norm, though traditions preserve different Vinayas. It matches the tested Vinaya distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: For Vinaya, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 20 specifically tests the boundary around Monastic discipline, procedures and rules.

Q21

21

Which pair best illustrates Buddhist lay patronage in texts?

- A. Anathapindika and Visakha.
- B. Kharavela and Rudradaman.
- C. Gargi and Maitreyi.
- D. Bhadrabahu and Sthulabhadra.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Textual examples should be supplemented by inscriptions from multi-social donors. It matches the tested lay support distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q21-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise lay support benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'anathapindika and visakha.'. [Q21-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise lay support benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'anathapindika and visakha.'. [Q21-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise lay support benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'anathapindika and visakha.'. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: For lay support, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 21 specifically tests the boundary around Anathapindika and Visakha.

Q22

22

Which is the most defensible statement on Buddhism and caste?

- A. It admitted no lower-status followers, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- B. It challenged birth superiority and widened religious access without abolishing caste society.
- C. It accepted birth as the sole basis of worth, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- D. It legally abolished varna in all kingdoms, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise social access benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'it challenged birth superiority and widened religious access without abolishing caste society.'. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct: A nuanced answer distinguishes salvific access from total social revolution. It matches the tested social access distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q22-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise social access benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'it challenged birth superiority and widened religious access without abolishing caste society.'. [Q22-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about social access into a universal claim. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: For social access, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 22 specifically tests the boundary around It challenged birth superiority and widened religious access without abolishing caste society.

Q23

23

Therigatha is historically valuable because it preserves:

- A. Ashoka's edicts, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- B. Kanishka's inscriptional council minutes, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- C. Verses attributed to early Buddhist nuns, through a later transmitted collection.
- D. The Digambara canon, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise women benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'verses attributed to early buddhist nuns, through a later transmitted collection.'. [Q23-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise women benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'verses attributed to early buddhist nuns, through a later transmitted collection.'. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct: It offers female renunciant voices but remains a redacted textual source. It matches the tested women distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise women benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'verses attributed to early buddhist nuns, through a later transmitted collection.'. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: For women, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 23 specifically tests the boundary around Verses attributed to early Buddhist nuns, through a later transmitted collection.

Q24

24

Which council is conventionally linked to a Vinaya dispute at Vaishali?

- A. The first Jain council.
- B. Kanishka's northern council, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.
- C. The Valabhi redaction.
- D. The second Buddhist council.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It telescopes chronology or attributes a gradual development in councils to one beginning. [Q24-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise councils benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'the second buddhist council.'. [Q24-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise councils benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'the second buddhist council.'. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Correct: The ten practices and exact schism relation vary in later accounts. It matches the tested councils distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: For councils, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 24 specifically tests the boundary around The second Buddhist council.

Q25

25

Why is 'the fourth Buddhist council' ambiguous?

- A. Northern Kanishka and Sri Lankan Aluvihara traditions use different fourth-council memories.
- B. It always means Valabhi, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- C. It occurred before the Buddha, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- D. No Buddhist text mentions councils, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Numbering hides school and regional differences. It matches the tested councils distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about councils into a universal claim. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise councils benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'northern kanishka and sri lankan aluvihara traditions use different fourth-council memories.'. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise councils benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'northern kanishka and sri lankan aluvihara traditions use different fourth-council memories.'. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: For councils, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 25 specifically tests the boundary around Northern Kanishka and Sri Lankan Aluvihara traditions use different fourth-council memories.

Q26

26

The complete Pali Tipitaka is the canon of:

- A. All Mahayana schools universally.
- B. Theravada, within the stated chronological and evidentiary limits.
- C. Ajivikas, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- D. Digambara Jainism, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the canons distinction. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct: It is indispensable but not the universal Buddhist canon. It matches the tested canons distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise canons benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'theravada.'. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the canons distinction. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: For canons, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 26 specifically tests the boundary around Theravada.

Q27

27

Chinese Buddhist translations are crucial because they:

- A. Replace the need for source criticism, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- B. Are all eyewitness records of the Buddha, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- C. Preserve Agamas, Vinayas and Indic works lost in original languages.
- D. Prove every Sanskrit text was Mahayana, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise canons benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'preserve agamas, vinayas and indic works lost in original languages.'. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about canons into a universal claim. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct: Translation date and vocabulary must still be evaluated. It matches the tested canons distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q27-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Its absolute wording turns a limited point about canons into a universal claim. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: For canons, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 27 specifically tests the boundary around Preserve Agamas, Vinayas and Indic works lost in original languages.

Q28

28

Theravada should not be equated simply with Hinayana because:

- A. Theravada began under Kanishka, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- B. Hinayana means Vajrayana, without separating early teaching from later systematisation.
- C. Theravada is a Jain sect, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- D. Hinayana is a later polemical label covering supposed lesser vehicles.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It telescopes chronology or attributes a gradual development in terminology to one beginning. [Q28-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise terminology benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'hinayana is a later polemical label covering supposed lesser vehicles.'. [Q28-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the terminology distinction. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct: Use precise lineage and canon terms instead of a polemical shortcut. It matches the tested terminology distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: For terminology, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 28 specifically tests the boundary around Hinayana is a later polemical label covering supposed lesser vehicles.

Q29

29

Sanghabhuti is associated with a commentary on:

- A. Sarvastivada Vinaya.
- B. Rig Veda, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.
- C. Jain Acharanga.
- D. Pali Visuddhimagga.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: He must be distinguished from Sanghabhadra and from Theravada. It matches the tested Sanghabhuti distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise sanghabhuti benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'sarvastivada vinaya.'. [Q29-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the sanghabhuti distinction. [Q29-C]

- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise sanghabhuti benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'sarvastivada vinaya.'. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: For Sanghabhuti, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 29 specifically tests the boundary around Sarvastivada Vinaya.

Q30

30

Dhanyakataka was a major Buddhist centre in:

- A. Gandhara.
- B. Andhra.
- C. Magadha.
- D. Kashmir.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise regional schools benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'andhra.'. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct: It belongs to the lower Krishna Buddhist zone and Mahasanghika context. It matches the tested regional schools distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise regional schools benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'andhra.'. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise regional schools benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'andhra.'. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: For regional schools, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 30 specifically tests the boundary around Andhra.

Q31

31

Maitreya is:

- A. The author of Madhyamaka, without requiring textual, inscriptional or archaeological qualification.
- B. Only another name for Avalokiteshvara, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- C. The future Buddha in both Theravada and Mahayana traditions.
- D. A past Jain Tirthankara, as though every school preserved the same chronology and canon.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise maitreya benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'the future buddha in both theravada and mahayana traditions.'. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise maitreya benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'the future buddha in both theravada and mahayana traditions.'. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct: In Mahayana he is also a Bodhisattva in Tushita, but the expectation is wider. It matches the tested Maitreya distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It transfers a doctrine or label across traditions instead of preserving the maitreya distinction. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: For Maitreya, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 31 specifically tests the boundary around The future Buddha in both Theravada and Mahayana traditions.

Q32

32

Which list gives the six common Mahayana paramitas?

- A. Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha, stupa, chaitya, vihara, treated as a uniform rule across regions and historical phases.
- B. Ahimsa, satya, asteya, brahmacharya, aparigraha, yajna.
- C. Form, feeling, perception, formations, consciousness, soul.
- D. Dana, shila, kshanti, virya, dhyana, prajna, within the stated chronological and evidentiary limits.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise paramitas benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'dana, shila, kshanti, virya, dhyana, prajna.'. [Q32-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise paramitas benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'dana, shila, kshanti, virya, dhyana, prajna.'. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: It conflicts with the precise paramitas benchmark; the defensible formulation is 'dana, shila, kshanti, virya, dhyana, prajna.'. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct: Some traditions expand the six to ten; the six are a core PYQ list. It matches the tested Paramitas distinction without erasing chronology or source limits. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: For Paramitas, fix the tradition and chronology before accepting a familiar term; question 32 specifically tests the boundary around Dana, shila, kshanti, virya, dhyana, prajna.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AND KEY DISCIPLINE

Official UPSC 2024 Set-A keys are named only where locally verified. Earlier unavailable keys remain inferred; the locally held 2026 key remains provisional/unreadable in extraction. Descriptive models are instructional, not official.

Prelims PYQ - 2018 GS-I Q71

With reference to the religious practices in India, the "Sthanakvasi" sect belongs to:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	Buddhism
B	Jainism
C	Vaishnavism
D	Shaivism

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence
- ANSWER: B - Jainism
- EXPLANATION: Sthanakvasi is a non-image-worship reform tradition within the Shvetambara Jain family.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: The affiliation is standard Jain sect history; its roots are late medieval/early modern and must not be projected into ancient Jainism.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Confirm the sect belongs to Jainism, then place Sthanakvasi within its non-image-worship reform lineage.

Memory hook: 2018 Q71: B - Jainism.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2018 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Assume any unfamiliar reform-sounding sect name must be modern or Buddhist. **Correct:** Sthanakvasi is a Shvetambara Jain reform lineage; keep it inside Jain sub-sect history.
- **Wrong:** Treat Sthanakvasi's non-image-worship stance as an ancient-period fact. **Correct:** Its distinct identity is a late medieval/early-modern reform, not a sixth-century BCE feature.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2018 GS-I Q74

With reference to Indian history, who among the following is a future Buddha, yet to come to save the world?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	Avalokiteshvara
B	Lokesvara
C	Maitreya
D	Padmapani

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence
- ANSWER: C - Maitreya
- EXPLANATION: Maitreya is the future Buddha. Avalokiteshvara/Lokesvara/Padmapani are names or forms associated with a major Bodhisattva of compassion.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: Maitreya expectation appears in both Theravada and Mahayana; do not describe it as exclusively Mahayana.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Separate 'future Buddha' (Maitreya) from Bodhisattva-of-compassion names before matching options.

Memory hook: 2018 Q74: C - Maitreya.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2018 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Pick any Bodhisattva-sounding name (Avalokiteshvara, Lokesvara, Padmapani) because they appear together. **Correct:** Only Maitreya is defined as the future Buddha; the others are forms/epithets of the Bodhisattva of compassion.
- **Wrong:** Treat Maitreya as exclusively a Mahayana idea. **Correct:** Future-Buddha expectation is attested in Theravada tradition too, so do not restrict it to one vehicle.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2019 GS-I Q9

Which of the following are features of Mahayana Buddhism? 1. Deification of the Buddha 2. Treading the path of Bodhisattvas 3. Image worship and rituals

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	1 only
B	1 and 2 only
C	2 and 3 only
D	1, 2 and 3

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence
- ANSWER: D - 1, 2 and 3
- EXPLANATION: UPSC's textbook framing treats all three as characteristic Mahayana developments.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: Historically, Mahayana was diverse; images and ritual were not exclusive to Mahayana, and 'deification' is a compressed textbook term.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Check each of the three statements against Mahayana's own doctrinal profile before accepting the combined 'all three' option.

Memory hook: 2019 Q9: D - 1, 2 and 3.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2019 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Default to the option that combines every statement whenever a list looks plausible. **Correct:** Verify deification, the Bodhisattva path and image worship individually against Mahayana's profile before combining them.
- **Wrong:** Assume image worship and ritual began only with Mahayana. **Correct:** Treat these as intensified, characteristic Mahayana developments, not features wholly absent elsewhere.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2020 GS-I Q22

Consider the statements: 1. Sthaviravadins belong to Mahayana Buddhism. 2. Lokottaravadin was an offshoot of the Mahasanghika sect. 3. The deification of Buddha by Mahasanghikas fostered Mahayana Buddhism.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	1 and 2 only
B	2 and 3 only
C	3 only
D	1, 2 and 3

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence
- ANSWER: B - 2 and 3 only
- EXPLANATION: Sthaviravadins are an early lineage, not Mahayana as such. Lokottaravada is Mahasanghika-linked, and Mahasanghika Buddha concepts are conventionally connected to Mahayana development.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: The genealogy is more complex than a direct one-school origin; the answer follows the question's standard historical framing.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Fix Sthaviravada as non-Mahayana first, then verify the Lokottaravada-Mahasanghika-Mahayana chain link by link.

Memory hook: 2020 Q22: B - 2 and 3 only.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2020 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Treat 'Sthaviravadin' as another name for Mahayana Buddhism. **Correct:** Sthaviravada is an early lineage distinct from Mahayana; do not collapse the two.
- **Wrong:** Read a three-statement genealogy as one unbroken chain. **Correct:** Test each link (Lokottaravada-Mahasanghika; Mahasanghika Buddha-concept-Mahayana) separately before accepting the combined statement.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2020 GS-I Q31

Which one of the following is the correct description of the term 'paramitas'?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	Earliest Dharmashastra texts in sutra style
B	Schools rejecting Vedic authority
C	Perfections whose attainment led to the Bodhisattva path
D	Powerful merchant guilds of early medieval South India

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence
- ANSWER: C - Perfections on the Bodhisattva path
- EXPLANATION: Paramitas are cultivated perfections; the common Mahayana list includes generosity, morality, patience, effort, meditation and wisdom.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: Theravada traditions also discuss parami; avoid saying the general idea of perfections is wholly absent outside Mahayana.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Match 'paramitas' to its technical sense before considering unrelated textbook distractors sharing the option list.

Memory hook: 2020 Q31: C - Perfections on the Bodhisattva path.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2020 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Confuse 'paramitas' with unrelated textbook terms (early Dharmashastra sutras, Vedic-rejecting schools, merchant guilds) sharing the option list. **Correct:** Anchor the term to its precise sense: perfections cultivated on the Bodhisattva path.
- **Wrong:** Treat paramitas as an exclusively Mahayana monopoly. **Correct:** Theravada also discusses parami, so qualify any exclusivity claim.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2020 GS-I Q71

Consider the pairs: 1. Parivrajaka - renunciant and wanderer 2. Shramana - priest with a high status 3. Upasaka - lay follower of Buddhism. Which are correctly matched?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	1 and 2 only
B	1 and 3 only
C	2 and 3 only
D	1, 2 and 3

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence

- ANSWER: B - 1 and 3 only
- EXPLANATION: Parivrajaka is a wanderer; upasaka a Buddhist lay follower. Shramana is an ascetic/striver, not a high-status priest.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: Shramana spans several renunciant traditions and is not a synonym for Buddhist monk alone.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Classify shramana as a broad renunciant category before matching the other two Pali terms in the set.

Memory hook: 2020 Q71: B - 1 and 3 only.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2020 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Treat 'shramana' as a status title equivalent to a priest. **Correct:** Shramana means striver/ascetic across several renunciant traditions, not a high-status priestly office.
- **Wrong:** Assume every term in a matching set belongs to one religion. **Correct:** Parivrajaka and shramana span traditions; only upasaka is Buddhism-specific here.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2022 GS-I Q55

Which among the following are Jaina texts? 1. Nettipakarana 2. Parishishtaparvan 3. Avadanashataka 4. Trishashtilakshana Mahapurana

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	1, 2 and 3
B	2 and 4 only
C	1, 3 and 4
D	2, 3 and 4

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence
- ANSWER: B - 2 and 4 only
- EXPLANATION: Parishishtaparvan and Trishashtilakshana Mahapurana are Jain; Nettipakarana and Avadanashataka are Buddhist.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: The item tests literary affiliation, not whether every text is canonical in the narrow sectarian sense.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Sort each of the four titles by tradition (Buddhist vs Jain) before selecting the option.

Memory hook: 2022 Q55: B - 2 and 4 only.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2022 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Assume all four listed titles share one affiliation because they appear in the same list. **Correct:** Sort each by its actual tradition first: Nettipakarana and Avadanashataka are Buddhist; Parishishtaparvan and Trishashtilakshana Mahapurana are Jain.
- **Wrong:** Require every listed text to be narrowly canonical before counting it. **Correct:** The question tests literary/religious affiliation, not strict canonical status.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2023 GS-I Q41

In which region was Dhanyakataka, which flourished as a prominent Buddhist centre under the Mahasanghikas, located?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	Andhra
B	Gandhara
C	Kalinga
D	Magadha

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence
- ANSWER: A - Andhra
- EXPLANATION: Dhanyakataka/Dharanikota belongs to the lower Krishna-Andhra Buddhist zone associated with Amaravati and Mahasanghika traditions.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: The exact relationship among regional schools, monuments and later texts should not be made more uniform than the evidence permits.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Anchor Dhanyakataka to the lower Krishna-Andhra Mahasanghika zone before considering other regions.

Memory hook: 2023 Q41: A - Andhra.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2023 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Confuse Dhanyakataka with a north-western or Gangetic Buddhist centre because 'Buddhist centre' sounds generic. **Correct:** Anchor it specifically to the lower Krishna-Andhra zone linked with Amaravati.
- **Wrong:** Assume every regional Buddhist school/monument network was uniform. **Correct:** Keep regional schools (Mahasanghika-Andhra here) distinct from other regional lineages.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Adjacent Prelims PYQ - 2023 GS-I Q42

Consider the statements: 1. The concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin. 2. Stupa was generally a repository of relics. 3. Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition. How many are correct?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	Only one
B	Only two
C	All three
D	None

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence
- ANSWER: B - Only two (statements 2 and 3)
- EXPLANATION: Buddhism extensively developed relic, commemorative and votive stupas, but mound/relic monument concepts predated or exceeded Buddhism.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: This is adjacent art-history ownership included because stupas are central material evidence for Buddhist institutional history.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Treat the stupa's Buddhist elaboration and its pre-existing mound/relic form as separate claims to verify.

Memory hook: 2023 Q42: B - Only two (statements 2 and 3).

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2023 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Assume the mound/relic monument concept is exclusively Buddhist in origin. **Correct:** Buddhism greatly elaborated the stupa form, but the underlying mound/relic idea is not solely a Buddhist invention.
- **Wrong:** Treat this as a Jainism/Buddhism-doctrine demand. **Correct:** Recognise it as adjacent Indian Art and Culture ownership, included here only because stupas are core material evidence for Buddhist institutional history.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2023 GS-I Q47

"Souls are not only the property of animal and plant life, but also of rocks, running water and many other natural objects." Which sect does this core belief reflect?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	Buddhism
B	Jainism
C	Shaivism
D	Vaishnavism

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY; high confidence
- ANSWER: B - Jainism
- EXPLANATION: Jain jiva theory extends life categories to earth-, water-, fire-, air- and plant-bodied beings, grounding radical ahimsa.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: Translate the ancient ontology carefully; it is not a modern biological classification.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Match the life-in-all-elements ontology to Jain jiva theory, not to a modern ecological reading.

Memory hook: 2023 Q47: B - Jainism.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2023 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Read 'souls in rocks and running water' as a modern ecological claim. **Correct:** This is the ancient Jain jiva classification (earth-, water-, fire-, air- and plant-bodied beings), not a biological theory.
- **Wrong:** Assign this belief to Buddhism because both are shramana traditions. **Correct:** This life-in-all-elements ontology and the ahimsa it grounds are specifically Jain.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2024 GS-I Q54

Gautama Buddha was generally known by which epithets? 1. Nayaputta 2. Shakyamuni 3. Tathagata

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	1 only
B	2 and 3 only
C	1, 2 and 3
D	None

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: OFFICIAL UPSC 2024 SET-A KEY VERIFIED LOCALLY
- ANSWER: B - 2 and 3 only
- EXPLANATION: Shakyamuni and Tathagata refer to Buddha; Nayaputta/Nataputta refers to Mahavira in Pali tradition.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: Spelling varies across Pali transliteration, but the person distinction is firm.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Separate Mahavira's Pali epithet (Nayaputta) from the Buddha's own epithets before selecting.

Memory hook: 2024 Q54: B - 2 and 3 only.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2024 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Treat Nayaputta/Nataputta as one of the Buddha's own names because it appears in the same list. **Correct:** Nayaputta refers to Mahavira in Pali sources, not to the Buddha.
- **Wrong:** Doubt Shakyamuni/Tathagata because of transliteration spelling variants. **Correct:** Spelling varies across Pali renderings, but both terms firmly denote the Buddha.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2024 GS-I Q64

Sanghabhuti, an Indian Buddhist monk who travelled to China at the end of the fourth century CE, authored a commentary on:

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	Prajnaparamita Sutra
B	Visuddhimagga
C	Sarvastivada Vinaya
D	Lalitavistara

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: OFFICIAL UPSC 2024 SET-A KEY VERIFIED LOCALLY
- ANSWER: C - Sarvastivada Vinaya
- EXPLANATION: The audited official route identifies Sanghabhuti with Sarvastivada Vinaya commentary.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: Do not confuse Sanghabhuti with Sanghabhadra, a different later Vaibhashika scholar, or with Theravada.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Distinguish Sanghabhuti from the similarly-named Sanghabhadra before assigning the Vinaya commentary.

Memory hook: 2024 Q64: C - Sarvastivada Vinaya.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2024 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Confuse Sanghabhuti with Sanghabhadra, a different and later Vaibhashika scholar. **Correct:** Keep the two similarly-named figures strictly separate; this is a deliberate exam trap.
- **Wrong:** Assume any Indian monk who travelled to China must be linked to Theravada. **Correct:** Sanghabhuti's documented work is a Sarvastivada Vinaya commentary.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Prelims PYQ - 2026 GS-I Q3

Among the four main forms of existence recognized in Jainism, which is not included?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	Deva (gods)
B	Yaksha (demi-gods)
C	Manushya (humans)
D	Tiryancha (animals and plants)

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - LOCAL 2026 KEY IS PROVISIONAL AND UNREADABLE IN TEXT EXTRACTION; high confidence
- ANSWER: B - Yaksha
- EXPLANATION: The four gatis are deva, manushya, naraki and tiryancha. Yaksha is not one of the four.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: The repository routing ledger lists the demand but not an answer; this package does not mislabel the inference as official.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: List the four Jain gatis first, then test each option against that fixed list.

Memory hook: 2026 Q3: B - Yaksha.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2026 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Accept a demi-god-sounding term (yaksha) as one of the four Jain gatis because it fits the 'otherworldly being' theme. **Correct:** The four gatis are deva, manushya, naraki and tiryancha; yaksha is not one of them.
- **Wrong:** Treat this 2026 key as officially confirmed. **Correct:** The local key is provisional and unreadable in text extraction; this answer is clearly labelled an inference, never presented as official.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Adjacent Prelims PYQ - 2026 GS-I Q12

What does an empty seat represent in the specific early Buddhist iconography question?

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	Meditation of the Buddha
B	Buddha's First Sermon
C	Mahaparinibbana
D	Mahabhinishkramana

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - LOCAL 2026 KEY IS PROVISIONAL AND UNREADABLE IN TEXT EXTRACTION; moderate confidence

- ANSWER: B - Buddha's First Sermon
- EXPLANATION: In the question's intended iconographic pairing, the empty throne/seat with the relevant sacred context signifies the Buddha's presence at the First Sermon.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: Empty seats can carry different meanings in different compositions; iconography must be read with associated wheel, tree, footprints and narrative setting.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Read the empty seat within its full iconographic scene, not as an isolated universal symbol.

Memory hook: 2026 Q12: B - Buddha's First Sermon.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2026 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Assume an empty seat/throne always carries one fixed meaning across all Buddhist art. **Correct:** Read the specific narrative context (wheel, tree, footprints) before assigning a meaning such as the First Sermon.
- **Wrong:** Treat this as owned Ancient-Indian-History content. **Correct:** This item is adjacent Indian Art and Culture ownership, included only for cross-topic iconographic awareness.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

Adjacent Prelims PYQ - 2026 GS-I Q15

Which statements on Amaravati Stupa are correct? 1. It was in the lower Krishna valley. 2. In India it was next only to Sanchi in size. 3. Its school influenced later South Indian sculpture and products travelled to Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia.

Evidence / comparison matrix

Option	Text
A	1 only
B	2 and 3 only
C	1 and 3 only
D	1, 2 and 3

Core teaching / solved analysis

- ANSWER STATUS: INFERRED ANSWER - LOCAL 2026 KEY IS PROVISIONAL AND UNREADABLE IN TEXT EXTRACTION; high confidence
- ANSWER: C - 1 and 3 only
- EXPLANATION: The lower Krishna location and wider artistic circulation are sound; the claim that it was merely next to Sanchi in size is not secure and is treated as incorrect.
- EVIDENCE AND LIMIT: This is adjacent art-history ownership. The option letter follows the extracted Set-A layout and is not presented as an official key.
- ELIMINATION METHOD: Verify the location and influence claims separately from the comparative size claim before combining them.

Memory hook: 2026 Q15: C - 1 and 3 only.

Must-know facts

- Question source: local UPSC 2026 Prelims GS-I paper.
- An inferred answer is never represented as an official UPSC key.

UPSC traps

- **Wrong:** Accept every claim in a multi-statement question (for example, 'next only to Sanchi in size') without checking each separately. **Correct:** The location and wider artistic influence are sound, but the relative-size ranking is not secure enough to accept.
- **Wrong:** Treat this as a core Jainism/Buddhism doctrinal demand. **Correct:** This is adjacent art-history ownership, routed here only because Amaravati is a major Buddhist-associated site.

Mains/PYQ use: PYQ route: term -> tradition/school -> chronology -> elimination -> caveat.

Study link: Routed official-paper demand.

PYQ discipline: Preserve the locally archived wording and the stated key status. An inferred or provisional answer is never promoted to an official UPSC key.

SOLVED MAINS PYQ - 2020 GS-I Q1: ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

Verified wording: The rock-cut architecture represents one of the most important sources of our knowledge of early Indian art and history. Discuss. (Answer in 150 words.)

Demand decoding: Explain why rock-cut monuments are historical sources, not merely art objects, and state their limits.

Instructional model answer (139 words):

Rock-cut monuments preserve architecture, inscriptions, images and spatial organisation in one durable archive. The Barabar caves, donated by Ashoka and Dasharatha to Ajivikas, reveal Mauryan polish and plural patronage, though sparse interiors disclose little about ordinary users. Bhaja, Karle and Nasik combine chaitya halls, viharas and donor inscriptions; Karle's merchant and Yavana gifts connect monasteries with western Deccan routes, but donors are not a census of believers. Ajanta's separate phases, Jataka paintings and enlarged viharas record changing worship and monastic life across centuries. Udayagiri-Khandagiri and Ellora add Jain and multi-religious histories. Thus rock-cut sites illuminate technology, patronage, institutions, trade and iconography. They must nevertheless be dated phase by phase and cross-checked with texts and surface archaeology, because a monument's survival cannot represent the whole society that produced it.

Why this earns marks: It answers the source question through named sites, states what each proves and closes with a method limit.

SOLVED MAINS PYQ - 2020 GS-I Q2: PALA BUDDHISM

Verified wording: Pala period is the most significant phase in the history of Buddhism in India. Enumerate. (Answer in 150 words.)

Demand decoding: Enumerate Pala contributions while qualifying the superlative.

Instructional model answer (142 words):

The Pala centuries were a major high point of late Indian Buddhism, although "most significant" should not erase the Buddha's age or Ashokan expansion. Dharmapala-linked Vikramashila joined Nalanda, Odantapuri and Somapura in a network of residential learning supported by landed and royal patronage; foundation traditions still require archaeological control. These mahaviharas advanced Mahayana, logic and Vajrayana scholarship and circulated teachers and manuscripts. Atisha Dipankara's journey to Tibet exemplifies trans-Himalayan transmission, but one biography cannot represent every route. Pala stone and bronze images and illustrated palm-leaf manuscripts influenced Nepal and Tibet, showing workshop and pilgrimage connections rather than Pala political rule abroad. Concentrated institutional wealth also created vulnerability when patronage and political conditions changed. The Pala phase was therefore decisive for scholastic, artistic and Himalayan Buddhist history, but one transformative peak within a much longer and regionally varied tradition.

Why this earns marks: Five enumerated contributions, one trans-Asian example and a qualified verdict directly answer the prompt.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain why the rise of Jainism and Buddhism cannot be reduced to urbanisation or varna protest alone. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (121 words):

Jainism and Buddhism arose in a favourable sixth-century BCE ecology, not from one mechanical cause. Towns such as Rajagriha and Vaishali, exchange networks and categories such as gahapati and setthi widened audiences and donation capacity. Magadha, Kosala and Vajji-type polities created warfare, extraction and courtly debate, while costly sacrifice and hierarchy made alternative ethics meaningful. Yet these conditions cannot derive Jain jiva-karma theory or Buddhist anatta and dependent origination. The broader shramana field also contained Ajivikas and materialists, proving that one setting generated divergent answers. Followers included rulers, merchants, cultivators, artisans, women and renouncers; merchant or anti-varna labels therefore remain partial. Context explains timing, social reach and institutional opportunity, whereas distinctive doctrine, discipline and organisation explain why two durable traditions emerged.

Why this earns marks: It gives four causal dimensions, named evidence and an explicit anti-monocausal qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Show how Jain doctrine connects ontology, ethics and liberation. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (125 words):

Jain ethics follows from its account of reality. Countless conscious jivas are entangled with ajiva, especially karmic matter attracted through activity and passions. This makes injury cosmologically serious: earth-, water-, fire-, air- and plant-bodied beings widen the field protected by ahimsa. Bondage proceeds through asrava and bandha; samvara stops fresh influx and nirjara removes accumulated karma. The Triratna-right faith, knowledge and conduct-organises this release, while the five vows discipline conduct. Ascetics observe mahavratas rigorously; householders use anuvratas and supplementary restraints, making social continuity possible without diluting the renunciant ideal. Anekantavada and syadvada later discipline knowledge and speech, but their mature systematisation should not be projected verbatim onto Mahavira. Jainism therefore joins plural souls, material karma, radical restraint and graded community ethics in one liberation programme.

Why this earns marks: The answer links technical terms causally and separates early doctrine from later systematisation.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Compare Jain and Buddhist conceptions of self, karma and liberation. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (183 words):

Jainism and Buddhism share karma, rebirth, renunciation and liberation, but construct opposite accounts of the person. Jain doctrine affirms innumerable enduring jivas whose consciousness is obscured by karmic matter. Activity and passion cause asrava and bandha; samvara and nirjara stop and remove karma. Moksha perfects the individual jiva rather than merging it into a creator. This ontology explains rigorous ahimsa and austerity, moderated for laity through anuvratas.

Early Buddhism analyses the person through five changing aggregates and denies a permanent independent self through anatta. Dependent origination explains causal continuity: intentional karma conditions rebirth without a transmigrating soul. Nirvana ends greed, hatred, delusion and the rebirth process; it is neither the destruction of an atman nor mere physical death. The Middle Way and Eightfold Path reject both indulgence and self-mortification.

Thus Jain karma is materially conceived bondage of an enduring soul, whereas Buddhist karma is ethical intention within a conditioned process. Both make liberation dependent on disciplined conduct and knowledge, not creator

grace. However, surviving formulations are transmitted and layered, and later Jain logic or Mahayana philosophy cannot automatically be assigned to the founders.

Why this earns marks: Parallel axes, precise mechanisms and an early-versus-later caveat produce analytical comparison.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine how council and canon traditions illuminate, but also complicate, Jain and Buddhist history. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (181 words):

Council traditions illuminate how religious communities remembered authority, discipline and textual loss, but they are not neutral institutional minutes. Jain accounts associate Pataliputra with preserving teachings after famine and migration under Sthulabhadra. Svetambara tradition links Valabhi in the mid-first millennium CE with final canonical redaction, whereas Digambaras hold that the original Angas were lost. The disagreement reveals real sectarian questions of memory and authority, while preventing a single canonical chronology.

Buddhist traditions remember Rajagriha for recitation after the Buddha's death, Vaishali for Vinaya disputes and a Theravada Pataliputra council under Ashoka and Moggaliputta Tissa. These narratives map disciplinary consolidation and mission memory. Yet schools preserve different details, and there is no single pan-Buddhist "fourth council": Sarvastivada-Kanishka accounts in Kashmir differ from Sri Lankan memory of writing the Pali canon.

Canons therefore preserve doctrine, disciplinary ideals and institutional classifications. Their oral transmission, school ownership, redaction and surviving manuscript dates complicate direct historical use. Inscriptions and archaeology must test where communities, donors and monuments actually existed. Councils are best treated as tradition-specific claims about legitimation and textual organisation, not as one uncontested timeline.

Why this earns marks: It compares both religions, names councils and explains what the disagreement itself proves.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Analyse the role of institutions, patronage and material culture in the spread of Jainism and Buddhism. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (200 words):

Doctrine travelled through institutions. Jain fourfold communities and Buddhist sanghas joined mobile specialists to settled lay supporters. Jain anuvratas enabled household participation, while Buddhist Vinaya organised residence, ordination and teaching. Gifts of food, robes, caves and land converted ethical affiliation into durable establishments.

Patronage was plural. Ashoka's inscriptions provide early evidence of Buddhist support, pilgrimage and concern for sangha unity, but his dhamma was broader than Buddhist doctrine. Kanishka is important for north-western Buddhist networks, although council details are later tradition. Merchants, artisans, women, monks, nuns and local rulers appear in donative settings; "royal religion" and "merchant religion" are both inadequate.

Material culture anchored memory and movement. Sanchi and Bharhut stupas, Karle's chaitya-vihara complex, Amaravati, Ajanta and Gandharan art connected relic, narrative, route and donor networks. Mathura images and ayagapatas, Udayagiri-Khandagiri and later western and southern temples mark Jain expansion. Monasteries also became educational centres, with Nalanda and later mahaviharas linking scholarship to Asian travel.

Spread remained regional. Buddhism moved to Sri Lanka, Central and East Asia and Southeast Asia through monastic, mercantile, diplomatic and translation networks; Jainism developed durable western and southern Indian bases. Institutions and objects enabled transmission, but neither one ruler nor one route explains the result.

Why this earns marks: It links institution, donor and site evidence to mechanisms, while retaining regional and source limits.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Why did Buddhism contract in much of India while Jainism persisted? Give a multi-causal and regionally sensitive answer. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (206 words):

The contrast is relative, not a story of Buddhist disappearance and unchanged Jain survival. Buddhist contraction varied by region and century. Shifts in royal and landed patronage weakened some large monasteries; changing routes and agrarian relations affected their economic bases. Brahmanical and devotional institutions competed, borrowed and absorbed practices, while Buddhist ritual and deity worlds also overlapped with them. Concentration in mahaviharas could increase vulnerability. Political violence and later raids damaged institutions such as Nalanda and Vikramashila, but cannot explain centuries of earlier transformation. Buddhism persisted in Himalayan and eastern zones, expanded across Asia and later experienced revival.

Jain communities relied on resilient fourfold organisation, scaled lay vows and dispersed local institutions. Mercantile and elite support, regional languages and literary cultures strengthened western and southern centres. Mathura, Gujarat-Rajasthan networks and Karnataka traditions show changing regional bases rather than one continuous core. Jain temple culture, sectarian organisation and scholarship adapted; persistence therefore did not mean doctrinal or ritual stasis.

The divergence arose from different institutional geographies combined with changing patronage, competition, assimilation and political economy. It should not be attributed solely to Muslim invasions, Brahmanical hostility, tantric "degeneration" or merchant support. Buddhism's Indian contraction coexisted with trans-Asian success, while Jainism's smaller geographic reach supported durable regional continuity.

Why this earns marks: It rejects every single-cause formula, compares institutional structures and ends with a graded regional verdict.